

EU summit in October will deliver closer ties

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Shared political ambition will drive enhanced EU strategic partnership

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While European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen's State of the Union speech called for Canada to become an "associate member" of the EU, there is no legal or institutional basis for that status in the EU treaties, and significant political hurdles at national and European levels will prevent its creation.

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The EU and Canada will nonetheless upgrade commercial and security ties, with initiatives in areas such as critical minerals, advanced technology and AI, conventional and clean energy, aerospace and defense, and labor mobility expected to be announced at the Canada-EU Summit on 29-30 October.

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US President Donald Trump's threat to levy tariffs against the EU and Canada if they press ahead is unlikely to deter closer cooperation, though US-Canada ties could further deteriorate and any new US levies would threaten to derail last year's EU-US agreement.

There is no legal framework for associate membership and political opposition will stymie efforts to create one. Von der Leyen's speech was designed to signal the EU's desire to broaden its geopolitical coalition, given the challenges the bloc is confronting from Russia, China, and the US (see: [Russia and China escalation risks to dominate European politics this fall](#) , 26 August 2026). "Associate membership," however, is a red herring. That category of relationship does not exist, and the hurdles to creating it are significant. Member states are reluctant to dilute the benefits of full EU membership or set a precedent for other states seeking closer EU ties. The idea of associate membership for Ukraine, for which the designation was first floated, met with stiff opposition in many EU capitals.

Strategic collaboration will broaden and deepen. The path of least resistance for elevating EU-Canada commercial ties is joint initiatives on critical minerals, advanced technology and AI, conventional and clean energy, and aerospace and defense. Both sides will work to ensure mutual inclusion in local content regimes wherever possible (see: [EU 'Buy European' requirements will support derisking from China](#) , 27 May 2026). Ottawa will also press for more favorable treatment in the EU's carbon border tax (CBAM). Already, Canada is the first non-European member of the €150 billion Security Action for Europe (SAFE) initiative (see: [Deep US defense ties will limit procurement diversification](#) , 15 December 2025). That will likely serve as a blueprint for strategic collaboration in priority sectors expected to be announced at the Canada-EU Summit on 29-30 October.

US tariff threats are unlikely to materialize. The term “associate membership” is a red flag for the Trump administration. Von der Leyen’s speech prompted Trump to threaten tariffs on both the EU and Canada if the concept is perceived as a “hostile act,” but sectoral trade and security agreements are not likely to provoke a tariff response. Although closer EU-Canada ties aim to build resilience for both economies amid US tariffs and broader geopolitical instability, neither seeks to antagonize Trump as transatlantic ties improve and Ottawa navigates its trade war with Washington (see: Transatlantic relations inch back from the precipice and US Daily , 9 September 2026).

CETA will remain the basis for trade. EU-Canada is already largely tariff-free under the Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA) struck in 2016. However, ten EU member states have still not ratified CETA, which points to the political challenges of further integration. In private, senior EU officials close to von der Leyen describe the upgrade as “CETA +”. Remaining tariffs and quotas, such as on Canadian agricultural products, are too politically sensitive to remove. Progress on non-tariff barriers will also be difficult, as Canada is mostly aligned with US standards. Opportunities for further liberalization are mostly on regulations and labor mobility (i.e. work visas and student exchanges). Still, there is room for improvement in several areas where the Commission can take the lead and unanimity among member states is not required.

The EU is Canada’s partner of choice for diversification. Carney poured cold water on “associate membership” talk following his address to the EU Parliament on 17 September, but reinforcing strategic ties with the EU and Canada’s European NATO allies is a core government priority. Ottawa’s efforts to streamline and accelerate domestic natural resource development, including liquefied natural gas exports to Europe, as well as build sovereign digital and AI capabilities are part of a broader agenda to hedge Canada’s economic dependence on the US (see: Carney’s variable geometry will supplement, not replace, Canada’s US ties , 26 March 2026). Polling indicates that Carney has significant domestic support for deeper commercial and security ties with the EU, with one recent survey showing 81% in favor of closer integration with the bloc.

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